people survive some of the hardest years of Myanmar's authoritarian period. The Taungoo USDP office provides a suite of social welfare assistance including small loans and other services to its members, a legacy of its prior status as a military veterans' assistance organization. In recent years the locus of USDP patronage has expanded somewhat, with the opening of a free medical clinic chaired by a USDP legislator in the 2011–15 parliament treating over 100 people per week. In early 2015 the NLD commenced its own funeral service in Taungoo, with the party now offering one hearse and a people mover for this purpose. It assists with approximately ten funerals per week at the request mostly of party members. While such assistance is a concrete demonstration of the confluence of social and political activism, it is important to note that the NLD funeral service, like the USDP's suite of social services, complements the diversity of welfare groups and reciprocity practices already operating in Taungoo that are discursively and organizationally tied to Buddhism.

POLITICAL ACTIVISM AND UNDERSTANDINGS OF 'THE POLITICAL'

Inherent to the assistance provided by both social and political networks in Taungoo is a deeply moral notion of citizenship which expects very little from the state. Indeed it emphasizes the role of citizens in providing care and assistance to the needy with a 'clean', 'pure', and 'loving' mindset. This language, drawn directly from Buddhist cosmology, frequently replaces appeals to 'rights' which carry connotations in Burmese socio-political discourse not of inviolable entitlement but of an uncertain chance to make claims to authorities (see Prasse-Freeman 2012; 2015a and b).

Even amidst the promise and optimism offered by the November 2015 elections, political candidates and party operatives were realistic about the kinds of changes an NLD government could bring. At a rural 'meet the candidate' event attended by local members of the NLD discussion focused at length on how the party promises to deliver a government that would be more 'cooperative' with local communities. The emphasis was placed on a notion of entitlement in which citizens must not just 'ask' for their rights — as opposed to them being inherently granted — but also take the lead in developmental social action, with support from government.

This focus on 'cooperation' of the state with local social welfare teams